with municipal order but then it is a religious book and should not be expected to delve into the intricacies of sewage systems.

The second spurious argument is that the Rig Vedic people were iron-wielding ‘Aryans’ who were at constant war with their enemies called ‘Dasas’ (the latter being identified as the Harappans or aboriginal tribes). The term ‘Arya’ is commonly used in Sanskrit literature, but is never used in a racial sense. It refers to a cultured or noble person—which means that all groups like to refer to themselves as Aryan and to their enemies as non-Aryan. The use of the word in a racial sense occurs in ancient Iran and modern Europe, but not in India. Similarly, we need to be careful with the use of the word Dasa to denote non-Aryan enemies, especially when the greatest of the ‘Aryan’ chieftains mentioned in the Rig Veda is a Dasa himself: Sudasa, son of Divodasa (more on him later). [15]

In other words, the Rig Veda hardly gives us a consistent picture of Arya–Dasa conflict. It is rather a mish-mash of tribal feuds between clans whose ethnic background can no longer be discerned. Their technology is decidedly Bronze Age and the use of iron appears many centuries later in the Atharva Veda if at all. [16] By all accounts, iron smelting was an indigenously developed technology that arose in Central India from the plentiful iron ore found there. It could not have been an imported technological advantage that the invaders exercised over the locals.

In my view, the more serious argument against identifying the Vedic Indians with the Harappans relates to the use of horses. The Rig Veda frequently mentions the bull and the horse. The former is a common theme in Harappan art but the horse appears to be conspicuously missing. I have not yet found a full explanation for this and perhaps the answer lies in the hundreds of unexcavated sites littered across India and Pakistan or in the thousands of bags of animal bones from earlier excavations that have not been examined for decades. Nonetheless, I would like to add two qualifications.

First, it is very likely that Harappans were at least familiar with the horse, even if it was not a commonly used animal. The horse was domesticated in